

What is a shooting star?

A shooting star looks like a fast streak of light in the night sky, lasting for just a second. Also called a meteor, it is not a star, but a small piece of rock or metal that burns up as it enters the Earth's atmosphere.

Millions of meteors enter the Earth's atmosphere every day.

Fading fast

A meteor's trail fades quickly because the meteor moves very fast—about 45 miles (70 km) per second.

Blazing a trail

A trail of light follows the meteor. As it travels, it rubs up against the gas in the atmosphere, making the gas glow.

The Hoba meteorite

Most meteors burn up in the atmosphere, but when one lands on Earth it is called a meteorite. The largest intact meteorite ever found weighs 66 tons (60 metric tons). It was found in Hoba West farm, Namibia, Africa.

